
State of the Nations: form guide for November rugby internationals

Published by

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Estimated reading time

10 min

Added on

2025-10-29

Address

<https://www.theguardian.com/sport/2025/oct/29/state-of-the-nations-form-guide-for-november-rugby-internationals>

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Argentina

World ranking 6

Perhaps the most frustrating side on the international circuit, capable of imperious and infuriating performances in equal measure. Their inconsistency is best summed up with a Rugby Championship campaign in which they lost their first match to New Zealand and Australia before winning the second. And they might have made it three in a row if [their "home" fixture against South Africa](#) had not been at Twickenham. Still, when they are on song they have a back row and a backline to die for.

Travel is no longer a problem given almost all their frontline players are based in England or France and two wins from matches against Wales, Scotland and England would represent progress in so far as demonstrating that they can bring their ability to win on the road to the northern hemisphere. The scrum is an area in need of improvement but there is much to like about the side Felipe Contepomi has built and it is worth keeping an eye on the fly-half Gerónimo Prisciantelli who looked assured on debut against the Springboks.

November fixtures Wales (Sun 9th), Scotland (Sun 16th), England (Sun 23rd)

Australia

World ranking 7

If last autumn was the campaign in which Joe Schmidt proved that reports of Australia's demise were premature, this can be the one that suggests they will be World Cup contenders. On reflection it was a strange Lions tour which took an eternity to get going, only to feel over before it started. At the time the Wallabies' late rally in the first Test felt less significant than it proved to be given how close they ran the Lions in Melbourne before sweeping them aside in Sydney. [A first win in Johannesburg at Ellis Park in 62 years](#) ensures history will be kinder to this year's Lions and Schmidt has, if nothing else, restored belief among the Australian public.

He could do with his side shaking the habit of having mountains to climb and this summer has shown something that we already knew – just how influential power players like Will Skelton, Taniela Tupou and Rob Valenti can be. Carter Gordon's return gives rise to more optimism – they are in need of a No 10 around whom to build a side – with the World Cup approaching on the horizon and though Schmidt is hampered this November with restrictions on players based in England and France, another step forward by the Wallabies would be welcome.

November fixtures England (Sat 1st), Italy (Sat 8th), Ireland (Sat 15th), France (Sat 22nd)

England

World ranking 5

We are approaching three years since Steve Borthwick's appointment and it can safely be said we are at the high point of his tenure to date. A Six Nations campaign that improved as the tournament wore on was followed by a mightily [impressive series win in Argentina](#). Taking the next step is a tricky one, however, with Borthwick having to reintegrate British & Irish Lions including the Northampton trio who came to form the core of his backline as well as his captain Maro Itoje.

The same could be said of Richard Wigglesworth who returns in a new role as defence coach and has no easy task considering how well England performed in that regard in Argentina. Borthwick still lacks depth at hooker, lock and inside-centre and whether he turns to Owen Farrell at any stage this season to address the latter will be fascinating.

For now, having been denied a week's preparation for the autumn, intrigue over who he hands the No 10 jersey to has been denied by expediency: George Ford keeps hold of it. Indeed, with a short run-up to England's opener against Australia, many of those who performed so well against the Pumas have been rewarded. It is the third game, against the All Blacks, where we might see something resembling what Sir Clive Woodward would always refer to as England's "gun" XV.

November fixtures Australia (Sat 1st), Fiji (Sat 8th), New Zealand (Sat 15th), Argentina (Sun 23rd)

France

World ranking 4

Antoine Dupont is not expected to make his comeback until late November at the earliest so will miss France's campaign but while the summer series in New Zealand ended in a 3-0 defeat, it served to highlight just how deep the talent pool goes considering how many players they were missing. The injury list has grown with fly-half Matthieu Jalibert and lock Romain Taofifenua pulling out after the weekend. Nolann Le Garrec is expected to wear the No 9 jersey in Dupont's absence while Esteban Capilla and Calvin Gourgues are a couple of youngsters who will show that the production line is still going strong if they get their chance.

Mickaël Guillard, adept at lock or in the back row, returned from New Zealand with his reputation enhanced and Fabien Galthié will be targeting three wins from three against Australia, Fiji and South Africa. The match against Fiji will be worth a watch but their blockbuster against the Springboks, where revenge for [their World Cup quarter-final defeat](#) is on the menu, is not to be missed. Expect both sides to name 7-1 benches in what promises to be the Test match of the year.

November fixtures South Africa (Sat 8th), Fiji (Sat 15th), Australia (Sat 22nd)

Ireland

World ranking 3

A lot appears to point to a difficult autumn for Ireland. Including additional call-ups they had 18 players on the British & Irish Lions tour of Australia, not to mention five coaches if we're including

Johnny Sexton. In addition, Ireland struggled by their own admission last autumn given so many of their players had hardly played for their provinces.

Andy Farrell's side have a habit of confounding expectations and Caelan Doris's return is a huge plus point. But they lock horns with the southern hemisphere's big three in November and give up home advantage against the All Blacks, even if Chicago holds happy memories. A trying autumn that exposes a post-Lions hangover may expedite the injection of fresh blood that appeared to be needed after a Six Nations campaign that ran out of steam.

It also feels like a big month for Sam Prendergast, who will be desperate to show Farrell he is the heir to Sexton's throne at 10 despite his omission from the Lions squad. Their fixture against New Zealand catches the eye given it marks a return to Soldier Field but Ireland's recent matches with South Africa have been captivating and the Dublin meeting promises more of the same.

November fixtures New Zealand (Sat 1st), Japan (Sat 8th), South Africa (Sat 22nd)

Italy

World ranking 10

It is likely to be another of those campaigns for Italy that shows the gap to the more established sides is still significant. There have been big wins in recent years and they currently [hold the wood over Wales](#), but Australia are fully expected to exact revenge for the 2022 defeat that precipitated Eddie Jones's second coming and South Africa are also visitors next month. A third match against Chile should at least bring some succour.

The summer began well enough with a record win over Namibia but a two-match series against the Springboks yielded one strong 40-minute showing and a 45-0 chastening defeat. The autumn may come too soon for Northampton's teenager Edoardo Todaro but he looks to be another eye-catching back to add to the Italian ranks.

November fixtures Australia (Sat 8th), South Africa (Sat 15th), Chile (Sat 22nd)

New Zealand

World ranking 2

It used to be an accusation of the All Blacks that they would peak between World Cups before flattering to deceive every four years but the increasing number of players taking overseas sabbaticals suggests the opposite. Richie Mo'unga, whose return next year was recently announced, is the latest case in point. In the meantime, with Scott Robertson proving himself to be a conservative selector, the All Blacks give the impression of a side clinging on to their place in the world's top four, relying more than supporters would like on ageing players.

They were good enough to see off the Wallabies twice but with the wounds of [the record defeat by South Africa](#) are still raw. In many ways, then, this autumn could be hugely significant for their 2027 World Cup chances. Cam Roigard has had his injury problems but he can tighten his grip on the No 9 jersey, Quinn Tupaea could establish himself as a regular starter while Peter Lakai is a back-rower to keep an eye on. History will tell us if Robertson has kept faith in the old guard for too long but again the All Blacks arrive with the look of a side raging against decline rather than as the standard bearers they were for so long.

November fixtures Ireland (Sat 1st), Scotland (Sat 8th), England (Sat 15th), Wales (Sat 22nd)

South Africa

World ranking 1

Back-to-back winners of the Rugby Championship for the first time in their history and once more they arrive in Europe as the southern hemisphere's leading light. The Springboks began their TRC campaign by throwing away a 22-0 lead against Australia – a performance that prompted widespread hand-wringing by supporters and was decried as "dog shit" by Rassie Erasmus. After [beating Argentina at Twickenham](#) thanks in no small part to their mighty scrum, Erasmus was understandably as happy as a pig in the brown stuff but conceded that the Boks are still a team in transition.

On the evidence of their entire campaign he is right but South Africa are still able to find a gear that eludes their rivals, as demonstrated with [the record victory in Wellington](#). And in Sacha Feinberg-Mngomezulu they have a fly-half who promises to take their game to greater heights. A bumper, five-match autumn schedule includes a reunion with Japan, [10 years on from the Brighton defeat](#), and a mouthwatering clash with France in Paris.

November fixtures Japan (Sat 1st), France (Sat 8th), Italy (Sat 15th), Ireland (Sat 22), Wales (Sat 29)

Scotland

World ranking 8

It is an important autumn for Gregor Townsend because those who believe he has taken Scotland

as far as he can will be quick to question his part-time consultancy role with Red Bull if things start to go sideways. On paper it is not the most challenging of campaigns with the USA and Tonga among the opponents but Scotland supporters will expect at least three wins with the All Blacks and Argentina the other opponents. A first ever win over the All Blacks would go some way to silencing Townsend's critics but continuing to give rookies more experience should be his top priority. After a nasty injury last season, this autumn could be the campaign in which Andy Onyeama-Christie shows his class on the international stage.

November fixtures USA (Sat 1st), New Zealand (Sat 8th), Argentina (Sun 16th), Tonga (Sun 23rd)

Wales

World ranking 12

The rot has been stopped at 18 defeats after [Wales levelled the summer series](#) against Japan at 1-1 and Steve Tandy is in position. But off-the-field issues rumble on and there is debate over how many professional clubs should exist. A look at the world rankings doesn't do much to improve things. They are 12th in the world rankings and cannot afford to slip any lower given the draw for the 2027 World Cup will be made in December. As the tournament will feature six pools, any movement down the rankings will give Wales a nightmare draw.

Matches against South Africa and New Zealand are likely to be damage limitation so those against Argentina and Japan take on all the more significance. Taulupe Faletau is out injured. In the pros column, Louis Rees-Zammit is back and though he is rusty, having picked up a foot injury early in his Bristol career, he has the X-factor to get the Principality faithful on their feet. And Tandy desperately needs supporters to keep faith with his side.

November fixtures Argentina (Sun 9th), Japan (Sat 15th), New Zealand (Sat 22), South Africa (Sat 29th)

Best of the rest

Samoa are the most notable absentees from the autumn internationals because they lost a playoff against Chile and are now busy in the last-chance saloon for World Cup qualification as a result. **Fiji** are by a distance the strongest of the touring sides from beyond the Rugby Championship but Eddie Jones will be hoping **Japan** can spring the odd surprise while World Rugby would love nothing more

than the **USA** causing an upset against Scotland to generate some optimism around the 2031 World Cup hosts. That **Georgia's** three home matches are against the USA, Canada and Japan demonstrates the difficulty they have in attracting world class opposition. At least the excellence of their referee Nika Amashukeli has been recognised.

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